Writing and submission checklist

Before you press "Submit"

Foundations of Clinical Research · Sessions 7–8 (7.3, 8.1–8.2)

Manuscript: *[Working title]*
Target journal: *[Journal]*
Checked by / date: *[Name(s), DD/MM/YYYY]*

Tick each item. Ask a co-author who did not write the section to check it against the tables.

Title and keywords

☐	Title states population, intervention/exposure, outcome and design; no abbreviations; within the limit
☐	3–6 keywords (MeSH where possible) that do not just repeat the title

Abstract

☐	Structured as the journal requires; within the word limit
☐	Primary outcome reported first, with effect size and 95% CI; numbers identical to the Results
☐	Conclusion matches the design (no spin, no causal words for observational data); registration number given

Introduction and Methods

☐	Introduction is a funnel: known, then unknown, then aim; ends with the aim or hypothesis
☐	Methods allow replication: design, setting, dates, eligibility, intervention/exposure, outcomes
☐	Sample size calculation, statistical methods, handling of missing data and software are described
☐	Ethics approval (committee, number) and consent procedure stated

Results and numbers

☐	Participant flow first (flow diagram with numbers and reasons at each step)
☐	Every percentage has its numerator and denominator; denominators add up
☐	Effect sizes with 95% CIs; exact p-values ($p = 0.042$, not $p < 0.05$; $p < 0.001$ allowed)
☐	Decimal places consistent; units given; each number in one place (text OR table)
☐	No interpretation in the Results; results of all pre-specified outcomes reported

Tables and figures

☐	Each stands alone: informative title, units, n per column, footnotes for abbreviations
☐	Numbers in tables match the text and the abstract
☐	Figures show the data (no 3-D, no truncated axes); resolution and format as required (e.g. ≥ 300 dpi)

Discussion and conclusion

☐	Six moves: answer, compare, explain, limitations, implications, conclusion
☐	Limitations are specific, with their likely direction of bias
☐	Language calibrated: "associated with" for observational studies; no "trend" for $p = 0.42$

Reporting guideline

☐	Correct guideline chosen (CONSORT, STROBE, STARD, PRISMA, other via EQUATOR)
☐	Checklist completed with page numbers; flow diagram included

Declarations

☐	Ethics, consent, registration, funding, competing interests (ICMJE forms) completed
☐	Data availability statement; use of AI disclosed; CRediT author contributions
☐	AI used only as the journal allows, and declared: see AI_Use_Guidance.pdf for the journal rules and an example statement
☐	All authors meet the ICMJE criteria and approved the final version; ORCID iDs added

References

☐	Journal style used consistently; every citation in the list and vice versa
☐	Each reference checked against the original; no retracted papers; DOIs added

Journal fit

☐	Scope, readership and article type fit; word, table and figure limits respected
☐	Journal is indexed (e.g. PubMed/MEDLINE, DOAJ) and not predatory; fees (APC) and licence known

Cover letter and submission package

☐	One-page cover letter to the named editor: question, main finding, why this journal
☐	Statements of originality, no simultaneous submission, preprint disclosed
☐	Title page, blinded manuscript (if required), figures, supplementary files, checklist, suggested reviewers

After acceptance: proofs

☐	Proofs checked within the deadline: author names, affiliations, numbers, tables, figures
☐	Only corrections, no new content; licence and open-access choices confirmed
☐	Paper shared: institution, repository (as allowed), colleagues and patients; registry updated with results